

Monetising the wave

As most corporate customers—who contribute a big chunk to Microsoft's revenues—did not warm up to Windows Vista and skipped the upgrade almost entirely, Windows 7 already has a captive audience that is due an upgrade. From the Microsoft perspective, this is a huge opportunity, believes Faraz Khalid, founder and CEO, GivePC Foundation. He explains, "Besides getting the 'early adopters,' Microsoft has a lot of corporate IT departments who are waiting to jump at the latest OS offering. Clearly, a huge opportunity to reclaim the ground they had lost with Vista."

Not only for Microsoft, the launch has brought in a plethora of opportuni-

ties for the IT industry and technologists alike, opine experts. Neville Burdan, general manager, Regional Microsoft Solutions Practice, Datacraft, says: "Some analysts are forecasting that Microsoft is poised to ship over 100 million copies of Windows 7 this year. To tap this opportunity, the IT industry needs to understand new ways to deliver and maintain these new-age computing machines."

Considering this, many monetising opportunities can be explored in the area of OS upgrade-related services, feel experts. Assessing the size of the opportunity from the ISVs' (independent software vendor) perspective, Maninder Singh, head, end user computing services, HCL Technologies, adds: "There are millions of desktops in organisations

across the globe that need upgradation. The average cost of such an upgradation, per machine, is over \$1000 (Rs 46,460 approx) which makes this a multi-billion dollar opportunity for ISVs."

Elaborating further, Mody says, "There are additional opportunities in testing applications for Windows 7 and advising clients on steps to make the applications of Windows 7 compatible." HCL Technologies, which is into remote infrastructure management, is also viewing this launch as a huge opportunity, says Singh.

On the other hand, there are others who feel that since it is a desktop OS or a client side OS, it is going to affect the user experience rather than the IT industry as a whole.

Window(s) gazing, wearing the users' lens!

According to users, with whom we interacted, there are areas where the OS scores very well. But there are a few glitches that may make the experience go sour!

Talking of its strength, Khalid feels that Windows 7 is by far the biggest OS launch event in the Microsoft history—given the stakes Microsoft has thrown the kitchen sink at this in all spheres, be it in the area of product engineering, design, marketing or support.

Many others say that it is 'Vista' done correctly. "Maybe Microsoft realised that if it could fix Vista's problems, people just might whole heartedly accept a new OS. But Windows 7 is not a mere 'Vista service pack.' Windows has got a lot of things right with this release and is definitely Microsoft's prettiest Windows yet, affirms Gaurav Gupta, a software engineer working with a Web 2.0 start-up based in New Delhi.

To give our readers a flavour of the new OS, here's a list of features that look both interesting as well as impressive in the new OS:

User interface. Microsoft has invested a great deal of thought on UI development, and the results are there for all to see, says Khalid. "It's not a sin-

gle change but a combination of many features which has made this possible. I also like new explorer enhancements like 'Libraries.' You can also backup your system into an external device, like a USB drive," Mody adds.

The OS also features a radically different taskbar that supports thumbnail previews and Jump lists, shares Khalid, all of which make the user experience much cleaner. The *Start Menu* too has been redesigned (XP users would find this radically different from the existing interface), and there are tonnes of nice touches that make the experience better. A more attractive look has been given to many applications like Word Pad, Paint and Calculator.

Security, beefed up. The security aspect has been made a lot better than the previous Microsoft OSes, says Rohit Sukhija, director—marketing, TeamF1 Inc., a US-based network and security embedded software company. "I have been using it for a couple of months now and can say that it is far less vulnerable to attacks, which is commendable," he adds. 'Bit locker to go' feature is a powerful security enabler, which allows users to not only have their whole hard disk drive en-

crypt but also encrypt and lock data on memory sticks, external hard drives, etc, adds Burdan.

Backward integration. The OS allows users to run their applications on Windows 7, which they were previously running on XP, says Sukhija. This gets enabled as a full copy of Windows XP resides on the OS, which users can use in the virtualisation mode (only available for free in Windows 7 Professional and Ultimate editions). This allows users to use their legacy applications. "This means you don't have to worry about the compatibility of your applications with Windows 7," adds Gagan Sethi, manager-operations, HCL Technologies.

Stability. This is by far the fastest and most stable Windows operating system ever built, feels Khalid. "I've been running Windows 7 RC (Release Candidate) edition for months now and it's yet to give me any problem. Background services don't hog as many resources and the overall experience is much improved. And yes, Microsoft has done away with the annoying User Access Control prompts too, which has been a perpetual nag point with its earlier OSes.

Excellent networking. In terms of networking, the concept of 'HomeGroup' is excellent, feels Mody. He explains, "I